vaccines available to all Indians in the fastest possible time. He particularly had insisted that the government mustn't distinguish between public and private players, and keep the eye on the target of achieving the collective goal. Following the PM's approval, the ICMR tied up with a Hyderabad-based private company called Bharat Biotech International Limited (BBIL) to develop a fully indigenous COVID-19 vaccine. Globally, eight candidates had already entered the human trial stage and India was in no mood to be left out of that race. After the official tie-up, the isolated strain was transferred by the NIV to Bharat Biotech. Other Indian private companies were not far behind either. The Serum Institute of India (SII) had already partnered with University of Oxford's vaccine project, becoming one of the seven institutions globally capable of mass manufacturing the vaccine. Zydus Cadila, too, was attempting to develop a DNA-based vaccine.

In view of these developments, Dr Paul and Prof. VijayRaghavan led VTF-initiated conversations with all potential vaccine manufacturers in India as well as abroad. The main foreign players in the advanced stages targeting mass production and availability by the third quarter of 2020 seemed to be Pfizer, Moderna, Johnson & Johnson and Sputnik. Initial conversations mostly indicated the kind of logistics required to be able to import, distribute and administer these vaccines successfully without wastage.

Meanwhile, Bharat Biotech had successfully developed its vaccine based on an inactivated virus which would trigger an immune response in the body to draw up a defence system against the infection. During the rest of the month, they would undergo toxicity studies in rats, mice and rabbits and submit their data to the DCGI in order to be cleared for Phase I human trials. Likewise, Zydus Cadila, too, would successfully develop the worlds' only DNA-based vaccine a few weeks into June, which would be capable of generating an immune response and pass the test for safety.

15 JUNE 2020

INDIA | 1,52,761 ACTIVE CASES | 9,945 DEATHS

WORLD | 30,52,471 ACTIVE CASES | 4,92,092 DEATHS